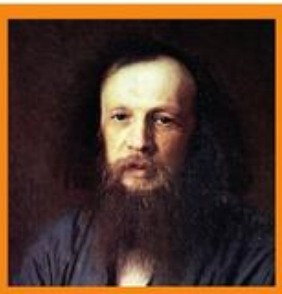
4 THE PERIODIC TABLE



The Periodic Table shows all the elements in the universe and is one of the most important tools that a chemist has. The arrangement of the elements allows us to understand trends in properties and make predictions. The modern Periodic Table was first presented in 1869 by a famous Russian chemist, Dmitri Mendeleev (left). This chapter explores some of the features of the Periodic Table.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand how elements are arranged in the Periodic Table:
  - in order of atomic number
  - in groups and periods
- Understand how to deduce the electronic configurations of the first 20 elements from their positions in the Periodic Table
- Understand how to use electrical conductivity and the acid–base character of oxides to classify elements as metals or non-metals
- Identify an element as a metal or a non-metal according to its position in the Periodic Table
- Understand how the electronic configuration of a main group element is related to its position in the Periodic Table
- Understand why elements in the same group of the Periodic Table have similar chemical properties
- Understand why the noble gases (Group 0) do not readily react

THE PERIODIC TABLE

The search for patterns in chemistry during the 19th century resulted in the modern Periodic Table. *The elements are arranged in order of atomic number* – the number of protons in the nuclei of the atoms.

The vertical columns are called **groups**

	1	2											3	4	5	6	7	0
1	H																	He
2	Li	Be											B	C	N	O	F	Ne
3	Na	Mg						transition metals					Al	Si	P	S	Cl	Ar
4	K	Ca	Sc	Ti	V	Cr	Mn	Fe	Co	Ni	Cu	Zn	Ga	Ge	As	Se	Br	Kr
5	Rb	Sr	Y	Zr	Nb	Mo	Tc	Ru	Rh	Pd	Ag	Cd	In	Sn	Sb	Te	I	Xe
6	Cs	Ba	·	Hf	Ta	W	Re	Os	Ir	Pt	Au	Hg	Tl	Pb	Bi	Po	At	Rn
7	Fr	Ra	:	Rf	Db	Sg	Bh	Hs	Mt	Ds	Rg	Cn	Nh	Fl	Mc	Lv	Ts	Og

The horizontal rows are called **periods**

·	La	Ce	Pr	Nd	Pm	Sm	Eu	Gd	Tb	Dy	Ho	Er	Tm	Yb	Lu
:	Ac	Th	Pa	U	Np	Pu	Am	Cm	Bk	Cf	Es	Fm	Md	No	Lr

lanthanoids

actinoids

▲ Figure 4.1 The Periodic Table

DID YOU KNOW?

You will sometimes see Group 0 labelled as Group 8. In more advanced Periodic Tables the groups are numbered from 1 to 18, including the transition metals.

REMINDER

For a larger version of the Periodic Table, including atomic numbers and other information, see Appendix A.

DID YOU KNOW?

Most International GCSE Periodic Tables stop at the end of the actinoid series, even though more elements continue to be discovered. Some tables completely omit the lanthanoids and actinoids because the emphasis in International GCSE is placed on a general understanding, which can easily be achieved with the main group and transition elements. Although sometimes called the rare earth metals, the lanthanoids are actually not that rare and are quite important in modern technology. Most of the actinoids are unstable and undergo radioactive decay.

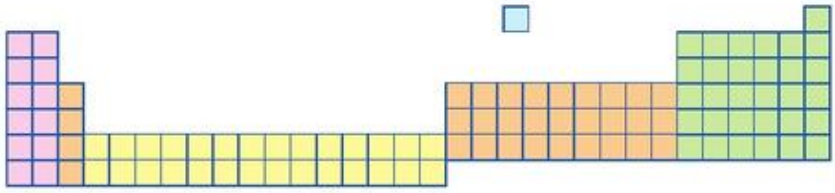
EXTENSION WORK

The third shell can actually hold up to 18 electrons. To explain why 2 electrons go into the fourth shell before the third shell is completely filled requires a more advanced understanding of electronic configurations. Each shell is actually made up of a series of subshells and some of these subshells overlap from one shell to another. The 4s subshell (which can hold 2 electrons) is lower in energy than the 3d subshell (which can hold 10 electrons) and so 2 electrons go into the fourth shell before the next 10 go into the third shell.

The vertical columns in the Periodic Table are called **groups**. The first seven groups are numbered from 1 to 7 and the final group is numbered 0. The elements in orange in Figure 4.1 are called the transition metals or transition elements. At this level, they are not usually included in the numbering of the groups. Some of the groups have names, e.g. Group 1 is the *alkali metals*, Group 7 is the *halogens* and Group 0 is the *noble gases*.

The horizontal rows in the Periodic Table are called **periods**. It is important to remember that hydrogen and helium make up Period 1.

The lanthanoids and actinoids are usually dropped out of their proper places and written separately at the bottom of the Periodic Table. There is a good reason for this. If you put them where they should be (as in Figure 4.2), everything has to be drawn slightly smaller to fit on the page. That makes it more difficult to read.



▲ Figure 4.2 The real shape of the Periodic Table

THE PERIODIC TABLE AND THE NUMBER OF PROTONS, NEUTRONS AND ELECTRONS

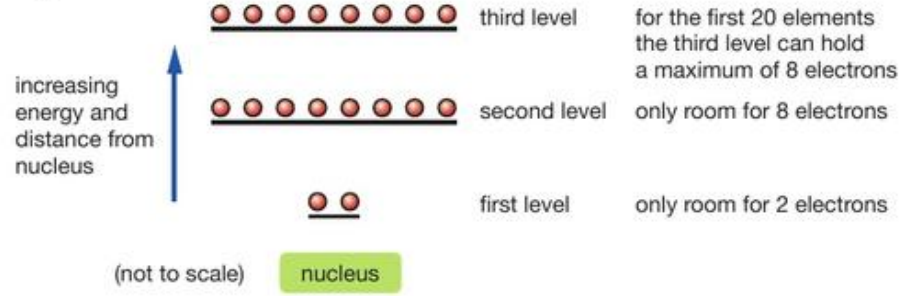
Most Periodic Tables have two numbers against each symbol. The atomic number will always be the smaller number. The other number will either be the mass number of the most common isotope of the element or the relative atomic mass of the element. The Periodic Table will tell you which.

You can use a Periodic Table to work out the number of protons, neutrons and electrons there are in atoms. Remember:

- the number of protons in an atom is equal to the atomic number
- the number of electrons in an atom is equal to the number of protons
- the number of neutrons in an atom = mass number – atomic number.

THE ARRANGEMENT OF THE ELECTRONS IN AN ATOM

The electrons move around the nucleus in a series of levels called **energy levels** or **shells**. Each energy level (shell) can only hold a certain number of electrons. Lower energy levels are always filled before higher ones. The lowest energy level is the closest one to the nucleus.



▲ Figure 4.3 The different energy levels for electrons in an atom showing the maximum number of electrons that each energy level (shell) can hold.

HOW TO WORK OUT THE ARRANGEMENT OF ELECTRONS IN AN ATOM

The arrangement of electrons in an atom is called its **electronic configuration**.

We will use chlorine as an example.

Look up the atomic number in the Periodic Table. (Make sure that you don't use the wrong number if you have a choice. The atomic number will always be the smaller one.)

The Periodic Table tells you that chlorine's atomic number is 17.

This tells you the number of protons. The number of electrons is equal to the number of protons.

There are 17 protons and so 17 electrons in a neutral chlorine atom.

Arrange the electrons in shells (energy levels), always completing an inner shell (lower energy level) before you go to an outer one. Remember that the first shell (lowest energy level) can take up to 2 electrons, the second one can take up to 8, and the third one also takes up to 8.

For chlorine the electrons will be arranged as follows: 2 in the first shell, 8 in the second shell and 7 in the third shell. This is written as 2, 8, 7. When you have finished, always check to make sure that the electrons add up to the right number, in this case 17.

DRAWING DIAGRAMS OF ELECTRONIC CONFIGURATIONS

When we draw a diagram of an atom we usually draw circles to represent the shells (energy levels); dots or crosses are then drawn on the circles to represent the electrons. You can choose to draw dots or crosses.

Hydrogen has 1 electron and helium has 2 in the first shell (lowest energy level).



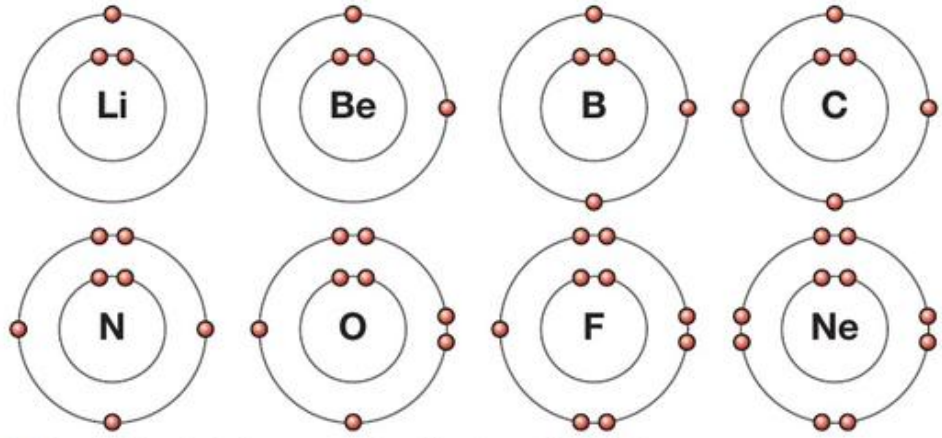
▲ Figure 4.4 Electronic arrangements of hydrogen and helium

KEY POINT

Drawing circles like this does not imply that the electrons are orbiting the nucleus along the circles.
The circles represent energy levels. The further away the level is from the nucleus, the higher its energy.
It is impossible to work out exactly how an electron is moving in that energy level.

The helium electrons are sometimes shown as a pair (as here), and sometimes as two separate electrons on opposite sides of the circle. Either form is acceptable.

The next 8 atoms are drawn like this:



▲ Figure 4.5 The electronic arrangements of the elements in Period 2

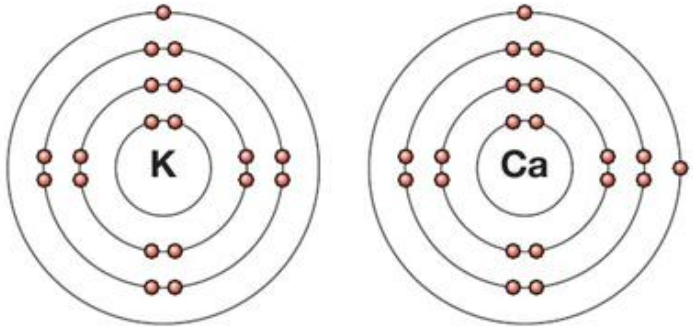
HINT

The terms 'shell' and 'energy level' are used quite interchangeably by chemists. To make things easier, we will just use one term, shell, from now on. If, however, you prefer the term energy level, that is absolutely fine and both terms will be accepted in the examination.

It does not matter at this level whether you draw the electrons singly or in pairs.

The atoms in the Periodic Table from sodium to argon fill the third shell in exactly the same way, and potassium and calcium start to fill the fourth shell.

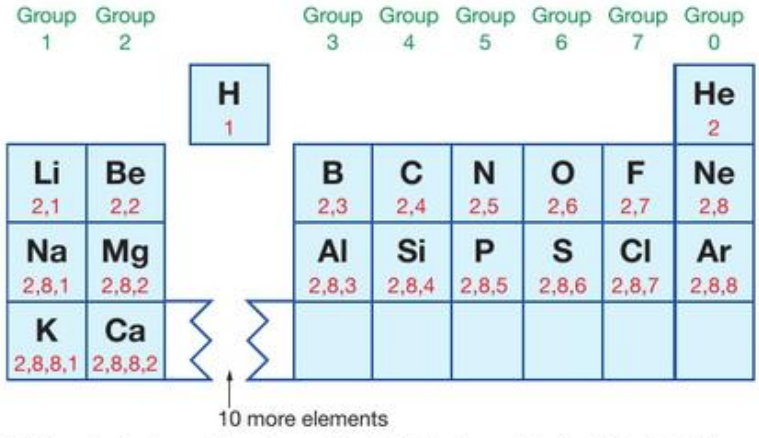
Potassium and calcium will look like this:



▲ Figure 4.6 Electronic arrangements of potassium and calcium

ELECTRONIC CONFIGURATIONS AND THE PERIODIC TABLE

The electronic configurations of the first 20 elements in the Periodic Table are shown in Figure 4.7.



▲ Figure 4.7 The electronic configurations of the first 20 elements in the Periodic Table

Two important facts:

- ***Elements in the same group in the Periodic Table have the same number of electrons in their outer shell.***
- ***The number of electrons in the outer shell is the same as the group number for Groups 1 to 7.***

So if you know that barium is in Group 2, you know it has 2 electrons in its outer shell, the same as all the other elements in Group 2. Iodine (Group 7) has 7 electrons in its outer shell. Lead (Group 4) has 4 electrons in its outer shell. Working out what is in their inner shells is much more difficult – the simple patterns we have described don't work beyond calcium.

The period number gives the number of occupied shells or the highest occupied shell.

So, calcium (electronic configuration = 2, 8, 8, 2) is in Period 4 and has four shells occupied; the outermost electron is in the fourth shell. Iodine is in Period 5 and has five occupied shells, and because it is also in Group 7 we can deduce that it has 7 electrons in the fifth shell.

ELEMENTS IN THE SAME GROUP IN THE PERIODIC TABLE HAVE SIMILAR CHEMICAL PROPERTIES

Groups in the Periodic Table contain elements with similar chemical properties – they react in the same way.

For example:

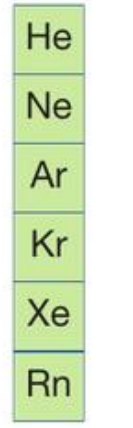
- all the elements in Group 1 react vigorously with water to form hydrogen and hydroxides with similar formulae: LiOH (lithium hydroxide), NaOH (sodium hydroxide), KOH (potassium hydroxide)
- all the elements in Group 7 react with hydrogen to form compounds with similar formulae: HF (hydrogen fluoride), HCl (hydrogen chloride), HBr (hydrogen bromide)
- all the elements in Group 2 form chlorides with similar formulae: $MgCl_2$, $CaCl_2$.

The reactions of atoms depend on how many electrons there are in their outer shell. These are the electrons which normally get involved when elements bond to other elements. Elements in the same group (apart from helium in Group 0) have the same number of electrons in their outer shell, therefore they react in similar ways.

THE NOBLE GASES

The Group 0 elements are known as the **noble gases** because they are almost completely unreactive, in fact the two at the top of the group, helium and neon, don't react with anything. The elements in Group 0 have 8 electrons in their outer shell (apart from helium, which has 2).

The lack of reactivity of the elements in Group 0 is associated with their electronic configurations. The noble gases are unreactive because *the outer shell is full, and so there is no tendency to lose, gain or share electrons in a chemical reaction*. You will learn more about how elements form compounds in Chapters 7 and 8.



▲ Figure 4.8 The noble gases

KEY POINT

The reason the noble gas group is usually called Group 0 and not Group 8 (which would seem more sensible because most of the elements have 8 electrons in their outer shell) is because when they were first discovered it was believed that noble gases did not combine with anything, they had zero combining power (valency). This is the only group where the group number does not tell you the number of electrons in the outer shell! The key point is that the noble gases (except helium) have 8 electrons in their outer shell. You will see in Chapters 7 and 8 that atoms tend to form compounds by losing/gaining or sharing electrons so that they have 8 electrons in their outer shell. The noble gases already have 8 electrons in their outer shell so they do not do that.

EXTENSION WORK

In reality, the outer shells of argon, krypton, xenon and radon are not full; in fact only helium and neon have full outer shells. The third shell can actually hold up to 18 electrons and the fourth up to 32 electrons.

METALS AND NON-METALS IN THE PERIODIC TABLE

The metals are on the left-hand side of the Periodic Table and the non-metals are on the right-hand side. Although the division into metals and non-metals is shown clearly in Figure 4.9, in practice there is a lot of uncertainty on the dividing line. For example, arsenic (As) has properties of both metals and non-metals.

KEY POINT

You may have noticed by now that hydrogen does not really fit into the Periodic Table properly. Although it has 1 electron in its outer shell, it is not in Group 1 because it does not have similar properties to the other elements in Group 1: it is not a metal and does not have similar chemical properties to the alkali metals.

EXTENSION WORK

If you are interested you could try an internet search for 'metallic hydrogen'.



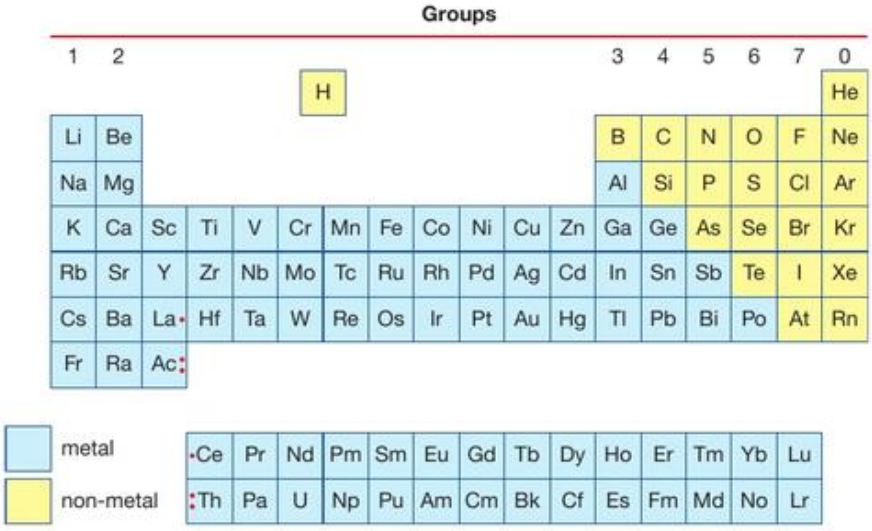
▲ Figure 4.10 Copper, like all other metals, conducts electricity.

KEY POINT

If a basic oxide is soluble in water it will dissolve to form an alkali. For example, sodium oxide reacts with water to form sodium hydroxide solution, an alkali. If an acidic oxide is soluble in water it will dissolve to form an acidic solution. For example, sulfur(IV) oxide reacts with water to form sulfurous acid.

KEY POINT

There are some exceptions to the rules. For example, some metals form amphoteric oxides (e.g. Al_2O_3), which react with acids and bases, and some non-metal oxides (e.g. CO) are neutral.



▲ Figure 4.9 Metals and non-metals

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN THE PROPERTIES OF METALS AND NON-METALS

There are many differences between the properties of metals and non-metals. Here, we will use two main ones to classify them: electrical conductivity and the acid–base character of their oxides.

Metals conduct electricity and non-metals do not generally conduct electricity. The reason that metals conduct electricity will be explained in Chapter 9 (it is due to the presence of delocalised electrons that are free to move). You may be familiar with the use of metals such as copper in electrical wires.

Non-metals do not conduct electricity (because there are no electrons that are free to move or mobile ions) but there are a few exceptions, such as graphite (a form of carbon) and silicon.

Metals generally form basic oxides. A basic oxide is one which reacts with acids to form salts. For example, copper forms copper(II) oxide (CuO). This reacts, for example, with sulfuric acid to form the salt copper(II) sulfate:

$$CuO + H_2SO_4 \rightarrow CuSO_4 + H_2O$$

copper(II) oxide + sulfuric acid → copper(II) sulfate + water

The reactions between bases and acids will be discussed in more detail in Chapter 17.

Non-metals generally form acidic oxides. You may be familiar, for example, with sulfur(IV) oxide (SO_2) being one of the gases responsible for acid rain. Acidic oxides react with bases/alkalis to form salts. For example, carbon dioxide, an acidic oxide, reacts with sodium hydroxide, an alkali:

$$CO_2 + 2NaOH \rightarrow Na_2CO_3 + H_2O$$

carbon dioxide + sodium hydroxide → sodium carbonate + water

Some other properties you might also associate with metals and non-metals are included in the list on the next page.



▲ Figure 4.11 Mercury has most of the properties of a metal (high density, shiny, conducts electricity, forms positive ions); the exception is that it is a liquid at room temperature.

Metals:

- tend to be solids with high melting and boiling points, and with relatively high densities (but as with several of the properties in this list, there are exceptions, for example mercury is a liquid)
- are shiny (have a metallic lustre) when they are polished or freshly cut
- are **malleable** (can be hammered into shape)
- are **ductile** (can be drawn into wires)
- are good conductors of electricity and heat
- form ionic compounds (see Chapter 7)
- form positive ions in their compounds (see Chapter 7).



▲ Figure 4.12 Sulfur crystals are shiny, but you wouldn't mistake them for a metal.

Non-metals:

- tend to have low melting and boiling points (there are some exceptions, e.g. carbon and silicon)
- tend to be brittle when they are solids
- don't have the same type of shine as metals
- don't usually conduct electricity; carbon (in the form of graphite) and silicon are again exceptions
- are poor conductors of heat (diamond is an exception; it is the best conductor of heat of all the elements)
- form both ionic and covalent compounds (see Chapters 7 and 8)
- tend to form negative ions in ionic compounds (see Chapter 7).

CHAPTER QUESTIONS

You will need to use the Periodic Table in Appendix A on page 320.

SKILLS CRITICAL THINKING 6

1 Answer the questions that follow using only the elements in this list:

caesium, chlorine, molybdenum, neon, nickel, nitrogen, strontium, tin.

a State the name of an element which is:
   i in Group 2
   ii in the same period as silicon
   iii in the same group as phosphorus
   iv in Period 6
   v a noble gas

b Divide the list of elements at the beginning of the question into two groups, metals and non-metals.

SKILLS INTERPRETATION 8

2 Draw diagrams to show the arrangement of the electrons in:

a sodium

b silicon

c sulfur